around welfare in a way that has not been done before. It turbo-charged older systems of social-welfare delivery and pushed newer delivery systems like DBTs on a massive scale.

In Mathura, for example, when I met a group of BJP district-level officials in July 2020, they told me that a large proportion of their daily work was the checking of beneficiary lists in their areas. ‘Right now, we are doing a collection of how many BPL cards were made by us,’ said Hemant Agarwal, BJP’s Mathura district vice president. ‘How many chulhas we distributed, how many cards we distributed in Ayushman Bharat, how many toilets we made. This listing is being done. It is being audited … So, for example, PM Awas Yojana has houses, those lists come to us. We check them from our side. We see if it is correct or not, whether there are complaints or not, if there is a problem or not.’[44] Through the pandemic-induced lockdown, the party’s city unit had conducted targeted Zoom meetings with separate local groups of beneficiaries, scheme by scheme: those with BPL cards who had recently been allocated electricity connections across UP, those who received chulhas under a government scheme and so on.

Nobody can claim that the governmental systems worked perfectly, or that there are no flaws in them. That would obviously be wrong. The point is that the BJP, using its ground machinery and targeted messaging, was able to reap the political benefits of its welfare spending, thus evolving a new model of politics in north India.

As one of the longest-serving independent MLAs in UP told me, ‘BJP has done work but it also has an old speciality: to do work which may be worth very little, as much as a speck of hair, but to dress it up so that it looks like a wonder.’[45]